In Dad's Own Words

How to ask him what's easy, what takes longer and where a hand is welcome, and how to set his account beside the family's.

You'd like to ask Dad how things are really going, and you don't want him to hear it as doubt. It helps to say plainly what you're doing: writing down how he manages now, while he's managing well, so nobody has to go on memory later.

This guide is for two short conversations. The first is with Dad. The second is among the people who see him. Neither is for deciding anything.

Who should be there

For the first conversation: Dad, and one person he's comfortable with, somewhere ordinary like his kitchen table. Keep it small, so it's a chat and not a meeting about him.

For the second: everyone who sees him regularly or does something for him. The one who drives him to appointments, the one who phones on Sunday evenings, the neighbor who brings in his bins. Someone who can't be there can send notes. Dad knows it's happening, and he's welcome at it.

One person takes notes. Tell Dad who it is, and that he can read them whenever he likes.

How to open

Ask before you describe. The National Institute on Aging's advice to families is that the best way to find out what someone needs is to ask them directly. AARP's planning guide adds: try not to anticipate what he'll say, just get the conversation started, and expect it to take place over time. [1] [2]

- “Dad, nothing's wrong. I'd like to write down how you do things now, while it's all going fine, so we're not guessing later. Would you tell me about your week?”
- “You know your own days better than any of us. I'd like your version first, in your words.”
- Say what it's for: a dated page to compare against. Say what it isn't for: deciding where he lives or what help he should have.

Questions to ask

Ask Dad

1. What does an ordinary week look like for you right now?

2. What's easy, and what do you most like doing for yourself?

3. Is there anything that takes a bit longer than it used to?

4. Where is a hand welcome, and where would you rather we left you to it?

Ask each other

1. What have you seen Dad do yourself, and when were you last there?
2. What do you do for him now, and roughly when did that start?
3. Is there anything Dad describes one way and you've seen another way?
4. What do we want to bring to his doctor or another professional, including which changes they'd want to hear about?

How to write down what was said

Keep Dad's own account separate from what the family has seen, and put a name and a date on every line. Where two accounts differ, write both and leave it there. A difference is something to mark, so a professional can look at it with Dad later. Nobody at the table has to be right.

WHAT WAS SAID OR SEEN	WHO SAID IT	WHEN	SEEN DIFFERENTLY BY
“I do my own shopping. I go on Tuesdays, when it's quiet.”	Dad	Today	
Brought the shopping in from the car in two trips.	Ruth	Last Tuesday	Dad says he's always done it in two

What not to decide yet

None of these can be settled at a kitchen table. Your notes are what you bring to the people who can look into them. Leave these open.

- Whether anything has really changed.
- What a change means, or what might be behind it.

- Whose account is the right one.
- Whether Dad should have more help, or what kind.
- Anything about his medications.

What you can agree on today

- Where the notes will be kept, and that Dad can see them.
- Who will take each open question to his doctor, his pharmacist or your care consultant.
- When you'd like to sit down together and look at the page again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't settle a difference between Dad's account and anyone else's, and it doesn't tell you what a professional will make of either. It gets both onto one dated page, with Dad's words first.

Ready for the next step?

You've heard Dad's account and set it beside the family's, with the differences left in. The care interview takes both through his everyday life area by area, keeps track of who said what, and turns it into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
2. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families